

BREAKING BARRIERS

- **Girls for Change:** When it comes to inspirational stories, here's one that would put a smile on your face. Located in Mumbai's and Asia's largest slum, Dharavi, there's a group of 13-15 year old girls who are beating the odds and making a difference. Girls for Change, part of Dharavi Diary, is led by documentary filmmaker Nawneet Ranjan, who works with Dharavi girls to help them create apps using the MIT App Inventor to address issues in their community – women's safety, water supply and girls' education. One of their apps, "Women Fight Back", is now in the Google Play Store – check it out for yourself. With Nawneet's efforts and guidance, the group of 30-35 young girls from Dharavi are learning to create apps and take part in the International Technovation Challenge.

www.dharavidiaary.com

- **Women Who Code:** Based in Bangalore, WWC is an organization dedicated to educating and inspiring women in technology. This novel effort enjoys close to 500 members since it was founded in late 2011. Functioning under the direction of Devangana Khokhar, Women Who Code are known for their free weekly technical study groups and larger format monthly events including tech talks, hack nights, and career trainings – all meant for deserving girl

students or young professionals who are trying to learn essential technical skills.

www.womenwhocode.com/bangalore

- **WeTech:** Their Afterschool program was launched last year, and the innovative program connects industry professionals from Qualcomm, Goldman Sachs, and Target with teams of middle school and high school girls in India and San Diego to serve as mentors and guide them through the 12-week Technovation curriculum. After the successful mentorship, the teams pitch their apps to a panel of industry professionals from leading tech companies such as Google, Intel and SAP. The top three teams receive prizes, but every young woman that participates walks away with the technical skills needed to develop an app, the confidence to present their ideas and the support of a mentor. <http://dgit.in/1ETUqkU>
- **Sheroos:** This is a jobs and careers community for women in India, committed to enhancing the quality and quantity of opportunities for women and investing in women professionals through various phases of their career. These include opportunities with women friendly employers, flex friendly formats, mompreneur programs, partnership programs and more. <http://sheroos.in>

be stimulated at school and at home to be vocal, to share their thoughts and ideas and to collaborate. More and more female graduates join companies but the companies experience drop-outs when they marry or give birth.

To tackle this situation, employers need to create a safe, respectful women-friendly environment by ensuring diversity & inclusion at workplace, zero-tolerance against gender-bias, stimulating women to grow further into their career and to take up additional challenges, providing mentorship and creating a good work/family/personal life balance to attract more women to become technologists."

To add to that, Aparna Khatri, Senior Director, Global Solutions Engineering, EMC, believes that for aspiring girls to become technologists, they require to be skilled and intelligent. "So the first step is to ensure that girls get the required education, both foundational and advanced. The trend has definitely improved over the last 20 years with the government and private sector's focus on education as well as people's understanding that technology is an area where women can grow and excel in their career. From 1-2 girls in a class of 60 pursuing engineering/diploma, the number has grown to 30 per cent.

What challenges have you faced as a woman employee in the field of technology?

 I started as a Manager in Accenture in 2003 and am now responsible for all technology delivery from Accenture India Delivery Center for our Resources clients (oil and gas, utilities, chemicals, and natural resources) for the EALA (Europe, Africa and Latin America) region.

In the earlier years, the biggest challenge was being able to relate to the wide diaspora of our teams in terms of background, age, and experience and 'carry each one along', win their 'buy in'. In the later years, the challenges involved getting the right skill set for the job, staying relevant to the client, and organization changes.

SHALU CHADHA
MANAGING DIRECTOR
ACCENTURE INDIA DELIVERY CENTER FOR
RESOURCES CLIENTS

Most tech companies have realized the advantage of a diverse workforce, and encourage recruitment of women employees and also provide the required flexibility during major life events including marriage and childbirth. Women should leverage this support and with enough drive, perseverance and hard work can definitely excel in the tech industry."

Pallavi Gupta, a Software Engineer working for Samsung R&D Institute, Bangalore in the Voice Recognition team, Mobile Division, feels that we don't see a lot of women entrepreneurs or leaders talking to the public about technological advance, barring a few. "For instance ISRO women scientists' who were seen celebrating during the successful launch of MoM, is something the nation reverberates with. There is a lack of emphasis on the achievements made by the women technologists and hence the consumers aren't quite aware of the same," according to her.

And if it all checks out, it's only a matter of time before we have more success stories like that of Manu Malhotra, Senior Manager, Engineering Software, HARMAN Connected Car. A techie at heart, she's been associated with innovative engineering work all throughout her career. "I am proud to be associated with